



Bacteriologist Sir Alexander Fleming surrounded by test tubes in his laboratory. Fleming discovered the antibiotic properties of penicillin in 1928.

IN THE SOVIET UNION, JOSEPH STALIN (1878–1953) began radical economic and social reform.

Abandoning the compromise of Vladimir Lenin's New Economic Policy (see 1921), Stalin launched a **Five-Year Plan** to transform the Soviet Union into a major industrial country. He cracked down on businessmen and successful peasants who had made money out of the revolution. Hundreds of "bourgeois experts"—people, such as engineers, who had been valued for their skills rather than their involvement in the revolution—were arrested and **convicted of sabotage**.

In China, Chiang Kai-shek (1887–1975), leader of the nationalist **Kuomintang** (National People's Party), was close to establishing his rule over the entire country. The warlords who ruled different areas of China either became his allies or were defeated by his army. In June, Kuomintang forces took Beijing, and in October Chiang Kai-shek formally established a national

government, but he still faced resistance. Former allies of the Kuomintang, the **communists** suffered heavy losses when Chiang Kai-shek turned against them in 1927. Forced out of the cities they continued their struggle in remote rural areas—a large area of mountainous Jiangxi and Fujian provinces came under the control of the communist leader Mao Zedong (see 1921).

Political violence was also widespread elsewhere. In Yugoslavia, hostility between Croats and Serbs led to the **killing of Croatian Peasant Party leader Stjepan Radić (1871–1928)**. He was shot by a Montenegrin Serb political opponent in the Yugoslav parliament on June 20, and died later of his wounds. With his realm torn apart by nationalist passions, the following year Yugoslavia's King Alexander I (1888–1934) banned political parties and assumed dictatorial powers.

In Mexico, **General Alvaro Obregón (1880–1928)**, the dominant figure in his country's

politics since 1920, was **assassinated** after being elected president for a second term. His killer, José de León Toral, was a member of the **Catholic Cristero** movement that had launched an armed rebellion in response to the Mexican government's anticlerical policies. The desire for stability after the shock of Obregón's assassination led to the formation of the **National Revolutionary Party**, which, under a variety of names, dominated Mexican politics for more than 70 years.

In Germany, stability seemed to have been achieved after the chaotic post-World War I period. In elections to the Reichstag in May, Adolf Hitler's extremist **Nazi Party won less than three percent of the popular vote**, compared with almost 30 percent for the moderate Social Democrats. Under the German Republic's rigorous proportional representation system, the Nazis' minimal support gained them 12 seats in parliament.

In August, Germany was one of the original signatories of an agreement for "the renunciation of war as an instrument of national policy." This supremely optimistic document, commonly known as the **Kellogg-Briand Pact** after US Secretary of State Frank B. Kellogg (1856–1937) and French Foreign Minister Aristide Briand (1862–1932), obliged states to only resort to war in self-defense. Within a year it had been signed by all the world's major powers.

Of more practical consequence was the **discovery of penicillin**.

Scottish scientist Alexander Fleming (1881–1955) accidentally discovered the antibiotic mold in contaminated specimen dishes, but the development of penicillin for medical use was the work of other scientists in the 1940s.



Prohibition era weapon

A sawn-off, double-barrelled shotgun hidden in a violin case was a typical weapon for an American gangster of the 1920s.

ON FEBRUARY 14, SEVEN PEOPLE WERE SHOT DEAD in a garage on Chicago's North Side. The perpetrators of the **St. Valentine's Day Massacre** were probably members of the gang headed by **Al Capone (1899–1947)**, a prominent figure in organized crime. The victims belonged to the rival gang of Bugs Moran. Both Capone and Moran drew their main income from bootlegging—the illegal trade in alcoholic drinks that flourished under prohibition (see 1920). The massacre focused public outrage on the crime and violence that was rife in American cities. The authorities were forced to take action, which led to the arrest and imprisonment of Capone on charges of tax evasion in 1931.

On March 4, Republican **Herbert Hoover (1874–1964)** was inaugurated as US president. His arrival in office coincided with a high point of complacency about US economic progress. Through the 1920s the US had become the world's first automobile-owning society, with 26 million cars on the road by 1929. Optimism and easy credit drove share prices on Wall



JOSEPH STALIN
(1878–1953)

Born Josif Dzhugashvili, in Georgia, Stalin joined Lenin's Bolsheviks in 1903. After Lenin's death he cleverly outmaneuvered other leading Bolsheviks to achieve dictatorial power by 1929. He ran a ruthless police state that murdered millions of its citizens, yet he presided over the country's transformation into a major industrial power and led it to victory over Nazi Germany in 1945.



Chinese suffering

Prisoners taken during fighting between Chinese nationalist forces and those of the northern warlord Zhang Zuolin.

